rockets could be made with drawings, India would have by now sent men to Mars.

Our routine at Vernon was something like this: a bus would take us to the SEP campus every morning at seven. On Mondays we worked till 5.30 pm, on Tuesdays and Thursdays till 5 pm, and on Wednesdays and Fridays till 4.30 pm. Sunday was a holiday. Every day after work, it was imperative for everyone to gather at the office apartment.

'Bring back lessons every day from work,' I told the team.

And they brought to the table every evening, their experiences and, specifically, details of the Viking subsystems they came across.

This is when it dawned on us that several subsystems of the Viking project were out of bounds for us, since the contract did not include them. This exposed our rudimentary knowledge in attempting to put together a rocket engine as much as the French's shrewdness in keeping intricacies out of the contract. For instance, we made sure that the contract gave us access to development of turbines, pumps and gas generators. Design and development of the combustion chamber, engine and nozzle were also part of it. Little did we know how to store gas. We had no idea, and according to the contract, we will have no access to closed-loop control system, the network of valves, thrust frame, pre-pressurisation and fill-and-drain system for gas and fuel. Without these, our rocket would be slightly better than a Diwali firecracker.

Desperation drove me to virtually everyone who mattered at SEP. With some I reasoned that the joint venture would be futile, at least for the Indian side, unless our scientists were included in the design and development of all the subsystems. With some who knew this, but still stuck to the written word of the contract, I pleaded. When there was still reluctance from some quarters, I used threat dipped in sadness, 'If the contract has to be implemented in the present form, we would have no choice but to go back without even attempting anything.'

The combination of tactics worked. The French wouldn't rewrite the contract, but unofficially allowed us to be part of everything that went into the Viking project. Some people like Morin were considerate, and hence